



AFRICAN CONNECTIONS
"Your Gateway to Africa"

Welcomes You to Benin



Mabo (Welcome in Fon)

Thank you for choosing African Connections to provide comprehensive tour services for your upcoming “Ghana, Togo, Benin Tour” scheduled for January 4th – 16th 2026 (12 nights/13 days).

African Connections, “AC” is your Gateway to Africa. We have been a leader in African travel for over 20 years and the entire AC Team is preparing for your upcoming visit to Benin.

We pride ourselves on delivery of outstanding concierge services and we are happy to assist you and provide you with information you’ll need to prepare for your journey.

When you reach Benin, we will assist you throughout your stay in Benin.

Our team is knowledgeable and professional and proud to show you the wonders of Benin, a country we know so well.

This welcome guide will provide you with information that will be helpful as you make your travel preparations.

Please review this information carefully. We welcome your questions and look forward to seeing you in Benin soon!

Your Tour

You should book your tickets so that you depart from the USA on January 3rd 2026, with your arrival in Ghana on January 4th 2026.

Your tickets should have you depart from Ghana on January 16th 2026, and arrive back in the United States on January 17th 2026.

Your tour begins when you arrive in Ghana on January 4th 2026 and ends when we see you off at the airport on January 16th 2026.

Benin Travel Requirements

Benin is a tourist friendly destination, but it is important that you are aware of travel requirements and have your travel documents ready well in advance of your departure date. Please read the following information carefully.

Passports and Visas

A valid passport is required for all international travel.

U.S. citizens need a visa to enter Benin for stays of up to 90 days. However, there are other requirements to meet, including:

Passport: A valid U.S. passport with at least one blank visa page

Proof of travel: Proof of return or onward flights

Proof of funds: Proof of sufficient funds for the duration of your stay

Proof of purpose: Documents showing the purpose of your trip

E-Visa Fee: \$ 70.15

Your passport must be valid for at least six months from the date of your arrival back in the United States. Check your passport expiration date to be sure it meets this requirement and if necessary, apply for a renewal as soon as possible. You will not be allowed to board your departure flight if your passport expiration date is within six months of your scheduled return to your home country.

Immunization and Medical Information

Yellow Fever Vaccination:

A current yellow fever vaccination is required if you are arriving from an infected area within 5 days. However, it is not required by US Citizens if you have not been in an infected area.

If you get the Yellow Fever vaccine, be sure this is indicated in your yellow International Certificate of Vaccination or Prophylaxis (ICVP). **It is your responsibility to comply with all immunization requirements.**

Malaria Prevention and other Immunizations:

Your doctor might also recommend other vaccinations which are not mandatory for travel to Togo. It is up to you to decide if you take any or all such recommended vaccinations as they are not required for entry into Benin.

While it is not mandatory, we strongly recommend that you acquire anti-malarial medication. Malaria is a serious potential (but treatable) health threat, and you should take necessary precautions to minimize your risk.

It is also a good idea to bring your favorite mosquito repellent to further protect yourself from the mosquitos that you might encounter.

Prescription Medications:

If you take prescription medication, you are responsible for determining their legality in Senegal and note the following:

- We advise you to bring enough of your medication with you.
- Always keep your medication in the original container.
- Carry a copy of your prescription(s).
- Pack your medicine in your carry-on luggage, not your checked luggage.

Travel Insurance

Travel Insurance is not included in your package. However, it is strongly recommended that you purchase travel insurance to cover any unexpected event that might interrupt or prevent your travel.

Our company offers optional travel insurance through Allianz Global, a leader in the travel insurance field. You can click on the link below or go to our website www.africanconnections-usa.com to get a quote.

<https://www.agentmaxonline.com/agentmaxweb/widgets/quotetool.html?widgetid=859099&accam=F212819&code=ABIYU4TLWGBGTNHC6ZWLRSKAR65GB6C5JLBJOIXR7QY3M6I5HDDHZDIECAM4JHS6KBOBIU5FYWBJM3BAHKTFTOR572B73AM4ZH74ZMNXXVK3YLBWT3Z3F4X4R3Z53LEU4>

Shopping in Benin

You will love shopping in Benin! Whether you're browsing for unique handicrafts in the bustling markets of Cotonou or exploring charming artisan stalls in towns like Ouidah and Abomey, Benin offers a vibrant and culturally rich shopping experience. From colorful wax-print fabrics and

handwoven textiles to intricate beadwork, bronze statues, wood carvings, and voodoo-inspired art, there's something special for every taste.

You'll find a beautiful blend of traditional craftsmanship and modern creativity, making it easy to discover meaningful souvenirs and one-of-a-kind treasures to take home with you.

Clothing and Packing

Bring comfortable, breathable clothing. Cotton and other light fabrics are ideal, as it will be warm and often humid throughout your stay. We recommend packing a light sweater or jacket for cooler mornings and evenings, and comfortable shoes or sandals for walking.

Note: Benin is a culturally rich and diverse country with both traditional and modern influences. In many areas—especially rural or religious communities—modest dress is appreciated. Avoid clothing that is too revealing, particularly when visiting sacred sites or interacting with local elders. There will be opportunities to relax or swim at hotels or coastal areas, so don't forget your swimsuit and a swim cover-up. A wide-brimmed hat, sunglasses, and sunscreen are also helpful for protection from the sun.

Don't bring electrical appliances and gadgets. The electric outlets in Benin are 220 volts, while U.S. appliances are 110 volts. **This means you will not be able to use your U.S. small appliances and devices in Benin.** The exceptions are laptops, phone chargers and other such devices which are usually universal and should work in Benin. You might need an adapter for these devices, however, as the outlets in Benin are a different shape than those common in the U.S.

You can bring your own adapter or buy one when you arrive as adapters are very inexpensive in Benin and are readily available.

Toiletries/Personal Items

Be sure you bring all your toiletries and personal items. While you will have opportunities to buy such things in Benin, you might not be able to find the brands you prefer.

Customs Requirements

Passengers' obligations at Benin Customs are outlined on the Benin Customs and Tax Authority website. For full details, please visit <https://douanes.gouv.bj/>

When you arrive in Benin you will pass through Benin Customs, and you might be asked if you have anything to declare. You must declare any commercial goods or currency more than \$10,000 that you bring into Benin.

Money/Credit and Debit Cards/ATM's:

Cash

There is no limit on the amount of money you can bring into Benin. However, as stated above, if you bring in more than \$10,000 in cash, you must declare it when you pass through customs on entry. If you bring in less than \$10,000, there is no need to declare any cash that you bring in.

You will have several opportunities to change your dollars for the local currency during your stay in Benin. Please note that it is advisable that you bring any cash that you bring in either \$100 or \$50 bills as smaller denominations will be exchanged for a significantly lower exchange rate.

ATMs

There are ATMs in all the major cities you visit, but you will pay an international fee and a local bank fee for ATM transactions in addition to possibly receiving a lower exchange rate for each transaction.

Credit and Debit Cards

There will be a few places where you can use your credit or debit card, primarily in major hotels, restaurants, and supermarkets. However, Benin is largely a cash-based economy, especially in markets, rural areas, and small businesses. If you plan to use your debit or credit card when available, be sure to notify your bank in advance that you'll be traveling to Benin. This will help prevent any fraud alerts or temporary blocks on your card while you're abroad.

Also, note, many of the businesses that take debit or credit cards use POS equipment which requires a pin number. While we all know our debit card pin number, most of us do not have or know a pin number for our credit cards. So, if you intend to use a credit card, contact your bank, and make sure you have and know the pin number associated with the card.

Note: the only credit cards accepted in Benin are Visa and Mastercard.

Food and Water

Your tour package includes breakfast daily and other specified meals (lunch/dinner), including a Welcome Dinner with Cultural Performances.

You will be able to buy meals that are not included in the tour package at restaurants that we have carefully selected. There will be many food choices and you will be able to sample delicious Beninese dishes, but more familiar dishes will also be available to you. The average cost of a meal with a soft drink and water, in Benin ranges from \$15-\$25.

Bottled water is readily available. However, the water in all of the hotels and restaurants that have been selected for you is potable and is safe for you to drink, use as ice cubes or to brush your teeth.

While some of your favorite snacks might be available in Benin, and we will make regular stops for you to stock up on snacks, fruit, and drinks during the trip, it is advisable for you to bring the special snacks that you prefer.

Hotels and Restaurants in Benin:

Hotels

You will be staying at hotels that have been carefully selected for you to ensure your comfort. These hotels are highly rated with clean comfortable rooms and well-trained staff. However, standards might vary from those to which you might be accustomed.

For example, while bath towels and hand towels are available and supplied at all the selected hotels, face cloths are not normally available. So, you should bring your own face cloth.

Rest assured; our ground staff will be available to address any issue that might arise.

Restaurants

We have carefully selected each of the restaurants you will visit on your tour. These restaurants will provide clean, wholesome food giving you the choice of local Beninese dishes or continental dishes that are more familiar.

While the food is tasty, Beninese restaurants are known for slow service, so you might have to exercise a bit of patience before your meal arrives. Whenever possible, our staff will help you to place your order in advance of arrival at a restaurant, to cut down on the wait time.

Cell Phone/Data Usage and Internet Service:

Before your departure to Benin contact your mobile phone, service provider and request international data service to access WhatsApp, or similar apps for internet-based communications. Such communications are significantly less costly than international roaming charges.

You could also ask for a one-month international voice package. While this could be costly, it is cheaper than the bill you will receive if you make calls without a call package.

If you make or receive international calls while you are in Benin and you do not have the appropriate international call/data packages, you will be shocked when you receive your telephone service billing statement.

Other information that might be helpful as you prepare for your trip:

Country Profile

Benin is located in West Africa, bordered by Togo to the west, Nigeria to the east, Burkina Faso and Niger to the north, and the Atlantic Ocean (Bight of Benin) to the south. Its geography transitions from coastal plains in the south to savannah and semi-arid regions in the north. The country has a tropical climate, with a rainy season (April–July, and again in September–October) and a dry season dominated by the Harmattan winds (December–March).

The capital of Benin is Porto-Novo, but the largest and most commercially active city is Cotonou, located along the coast. Other major towns include Parakou, Abomey, and Ouidah. Benin has a population of approximately 13 million people, made up of various ethnic groups including the Fon, Yoruba, Bariba, and Dendi. The majority of the population practices traditional African religions and Christianity, with Islam also present, especially in the north.

Historically, Benin was home to the powerful Kingdom of Dahomey, renowned for its military strength and all-female warrior units. The region became a central hub in the transatlantic slave trade before being colonized by the French in the late 19th century. Benin gained its independence from France in 1960. Today, Benin is recognized for its peaceful democratic governance, rich cultural heritage, and vibrant artistic traditions.

Geography:

Benin, officially the Republic of Benin, is located in West Africa, stretching from the Gulf of Guinea in the south to the Sahel region in the north. It is bordered by Togo to the west, Nigeria to the east, Burkina Faso to the northwest, and Niger to the northeast. Benin also has a coastline along the Atlantic Ocean, with access to international maritime trade routes via the Port of Cotonou.

The country spans approximately 114,763 square kilometers (44,310 sq mi) and has a population of around 13 million people. Benin is a unitary presidential republic and is widely regarded for its democratic institutions and political stability in the region. Since gaining independence from France in 1960, Benin has made significant progress in governance and civil society. It operates under a multi-party system and has held several peaceful transfers of power—an achievement that stands out in the broader regional context.

Economy:

The economy of Benin is largely driven by agriculture, trade, and services. A significant portion of the population is employed in subsistence farming, with cotton being the country's primary export crop. Other major agricultural products include maize, cassava, yams, and palm oil. Benin serves as a key trade gateway for landlocked countries like Niger and Burkina Faso, thanks to its strategic coastal location and the bustling Port of Cotonou. The informal trade sector—especially with neighboring Nigeria—also plays a major role in the country's economic activity. While Benin has modest natural resources, including limestone, marble, and some offshore oil prospects, its economic progress is increasingly tied to investment in infrastructure, education, and regional integration. In recent years, the government has focused on economic reforms and diversification, with growing interest in tourism and digital innovation.

The Currency

The West African CFA Franc is the official currency of Benin. The currency code is XOF, and it is commonly represented as CFA. The CFA franc is pegged to the euro, which helps maintain currency stability, but exchange rates with the U.S. dollar may vary. You will be able to exchange U.S. dollars for CFA francs at local banks or currency exchange offices once you arrive in Benin. There is no limit on the amount of cash you can bring into Benin. However, you must declare any amount over \$10,000 USD (or equivalent) upon entry. Amounts below that do not require declaration.

Language:

The official language of Benin is French, a legacy of its history as part of French West Africa under colonial rule. French is used in government, education, and business. However, like many countries in the region, only a portion of the population speaks French fluently in daily life. Benin is linguistically diverse, with over 50 local languages spoken across the country. Among the most widely spoken are Fon, Yoruba, Bariba, and Dendi. In southern Benin, Fon is the dominant language, while Yoruba is common in areas near the Nigerian border. Despite the variety of languages, you should not have any difficulty communicating with locals, especially in major cities and tourist areas where people are accustomed to interacting with visitors.

Government:

Benin is a republic with a presidential system of government. The President of Benin is both the head of state and head of government, elected by popular vote for a five-year term, renewable once. Benin transitioned to democratic rule in the 1990s after years of military and single-party governance, and it has since become one of West Africa's more stable democracies. The constitution of Benin, adopted in 1990, established a system based on three branches of government: The Executive, the Legislative, and the Judiciary. The president appoints ministers and oversees national policy, while the National Assembly serves as the legislative body. The judiciary operates independently. Elections are held every five years, and Benin has earned praise for peaceful transitions of power and increasing civic engagement.

Current President: Patrice Talon

Vice President: Mariama Chabi Talata

History:

Before European colonization, Benin was home to several powerful kingdoms, most notably the Kingdom of Dahomey, which rose to prominence in the 17th century. Centered in present-day Abomey, the Dahomey Kingdom was known for its highly organized political system, sophisticated military—including an elite corps of female warriors—and its role in regional trade networks. The kingdom became a major player in the transatlantic slave trade, exchanging captives for European goods, including firearms. Portuguese explorers were among the first Europeans to reach the Benin coast in the late 15th century, followed by the French in the 19th century. France gradually took control of the region, and by 1894, the territory was fully colonized and became known as French Dahomey, part of French West Africa.

In the 20th century, movements for independence gained momentum. Influential leaders such as Hubert Maga played key roles in advocating for self-rule. On August 1, 1960, Benin gained

independence from France, initially under the name Dahomey. After a series of political changes and coups, the country was renamed the Republic of Benin in 1975.

Benin transitioned to multi-party democracy in the 1990s, becoming one of the first African nations to successfully implement a peaceful transfer of power through elections.

Climate:

Benin has a tropical climate that differs between the humid coastal south and the drier savannah north, and January falls within the dry season across the country. This period is influenced by the Harmattan winds from the Sahara, which bring dry air, cooler nights, and a light dust haze in many areas. In the southern coastal areas, including Cotonou, Ouidah, and Porto-Novo, January is warm and relatively dry, with little to no rainfall. Daytime temperatures generally range from 77°F to 88°F (25°C to 31°C), while nighttime lows hover around 72°F (22°C). Humidity levels are lower compared to the rainy season, and the ocean breeze keeps conditions pleasant, making it an excellent time for sightseeing, beach visits, and exploring coastal towns. In northern Benin, including cities such as Parakou and Natitingou, January is much drier and hotter during the day, with temperatures ranging from 84°F to 95°F (29°C to 35°C). However, nights and early mornings can be surprisingly cool, sometimes dropping to around 59°F (15°C). The Harmattan winds may create hazy skies and reduced visibility, but they also bring relief from humidity.

Overall, January is one of the best months to visit Benin, offering abundant sunshine, dry weather, and comfortable conditions for travel. The dry season makes road travel easier, and it's a great time for wildlife viewing in the country's national parks as animals gather around remaining water sources. Cultural events and vibrant local life also provide travelers with enriching experiences during this lively and welcoming time of year.

Frequently Asked Questions

General Travel Information

1. Do I need a visa to visit Benin?

Yes, U.S. citizens need a visa to enter Benin. You can obtain an e-Visa online before arrival or get a visa on arrival at Beninese airport. Your passport must be valid for at least six months beyond your travel dates.

2. How can I apply for a visa?

You can apply for a visa online via the Benin e-Visa Portal or upon arrival at Benin Airport with entry visas cost of \$70.15. Check our website for the latest visa information and application links.

3. What vaccinations do I need before traveling?

A Yellow Fever vaccination is required for entry into Benin. Other recommended vaccines include Hepatitis A & B, typhoid, tetanus, and malaria prophylaxis.

4. Is Benin safe for tourists?

Benin is considered relatively safe for travelers compared to many other countries in the region. However, visitors should exercise general caution, especially in busy urban areas and markets where petty theft, such as pickpocketing, can occur. It's advisable to avoid walking alone at night, particularly in unfamiliar neighborhoods. Tourists should also refrain from carrying large amounts of cash and keep valuables secure. For transportation, it's best to use registered taxis or reputable ride-hailing services where available. Staying aware of your surroundings and following local advice will help ensure a safe and enjoyable visit.

5. What is the best time to visit Benin?

January is one of the best months to visit Benin, offering abundant sunshine, dry weather, and comfortable conditions for travel. The dry season makes road travel easier, and it's a great time for wildlife viewing in the country's national parks as animals gather around remaining water sources. Cultural events and vibrant local life also provide travelers with enriching experiences during this lively and welcoming time of year.

6. What is the dress code in Benin?

Bring comfortable, breathable clothing. Cotton and other light fabrics are ideal, as it will be warm and often humid throughout your stay. We recommend packing a light sweater or jacket for cooler mornings and evenings.

7. Are public toilets available at tourist sites?

Public toilets are available at major tourist attractions, but they may not always be well-maintained. Carry tissues and hand sanitizer.

8. Is there internet access?

Hotels, cafes, and restaurants in major cities offer Wi-Fi. A local SIM card is recommended for better mobile internet access.

9. Is it allowed to take photographs of people?

Always ask for permission before photographing individuals, especially in rural areas and markets.

10. What fitness level is required for sightseeing?

A moderate fitness level is recommended, especially for excursions to natural sites and islands.

11. What kind of shoes should I wear?

Comfortable walking shoes are recommended

12. How is the power supply in Benin?

The electric outlets in Benin are 220 volts, while U.S. appliances are 110 volts. This means you will not be able to use your U.S. small appliances and devices in Benin. The exceptions are laptops, phone chargers and other such devices which are usually universal and should work in Benin. You might need an adapter for these devices, however, as the outlets in Benin are a different shape than those common in the U.S.

13. Can I drink alcohol in Benin?

Yes, alcohol is available in hotels, restaurants, and bars throughout Benin. While Benin has a mix of religious and cultural practices, including Christianity, Islam, and traditional beliefs, alcohol is generally accessible and socially accepted in most areas. However, availability may be more limited in predominantly Muslim communities, especially in the northern regions. Visitors should always be respectful of local customs and consume alcohol responsibly.

14. Is smoking allowed in Benin?

Smoking is allowed in outdoor areas but is restricted in enclosed public spaces.

15. What food options are available in Benin?

In the hotels, a full buffet breakfast is provided each day. Beninese cuisine is flavorful and diverse, featuring traditional dishes such as pâte (a dough-like maize or cassava dish served with sauce), amiwo (spiced cornmeal often served with meat or fish), and akassa (fermented corn dough served with spicy sauces). Popular proteins include grilled fish, goat, and chicken. Vegetarian options are also available and often include beans, rice, local vegetables, and flavorful tomato-based sauces. Meals are typically accompanied by fresh tropical fruits or juices.

Money & Costs

16. What currency is used in Benin?

The West African CFA Franc (XOF) is the official currency. Credit and debit cards are accepted in major hotels and restaurants, but cash is preferred in markets and rural areas.

17. How much does a meal cost in Benin?

A meal at a mid-range restaurant costs about \$15-\$25, while street food or casual dining can be around \$5-\$10.

18. Can I use U.S. dollars in Benin?

U.S. dollars are not widely accepted. It is best to exchange money at banks or Forex Bureaus.

Transportation & Getting Around

19. Do I need an international driver's license to rent a car?

Yes, an International Driving Permit (IDP) is required to rent a car. Traffic conditions can be hectic, so hiring a driver is recommended.

20. Is public transportation safe?

Public transportation, such as minibuses and shared taxis, can be crowded and confusing. Tourists are advised to use private taxis or ride-hailing services.

Health & Safety

21. Is tap water safe to drink?

We will supply you with bottled water each day. It is also available in your hotel rooms. Although the locals all drink tap water it is very heavily chlorinated and is fine for brushing teeth and bathing, but is not recommended for drinking. The hotels and the restaurants that we select for you, all use purified water to make their ice cubes. So, you should feel free to add ice cubes to your drinks.

22. Do I need travel insurance?

Yes, travel insurance is highly recommended for medical emergencies, lost luggage, and trip cancellations.

However, our company offers optional travel insurance through Allianz Global, a leader in the travel insurance field. You can click the link below or visit our website, www.africanconnections-usa.com, to get a quote.

<https://www.agentmaxonline.com/agentmaxweb/widgets/quotetool.html?widgetid=859099&cam=F212819&code=ABIYU4TLWGBGTNHC6ZWLRSKAR65GB6C5JLBJOIXR7QY3M6I5HDDHZDIECAM4JHS6KBOBIU5FYWBJM3BAHKTFTOR572B73AM4ZH74ZMNXVK3YLBWT3Z3F4X4R3Z53LEU4>

23. Should I bring my own medicine?

Bring sufficient prescribed medication for your trip. Pharmacies are available, but specific medicines may not always be in stock.

Activities

24. Is there time for shopping?

Yes! Benin is known for its lively and colorful markets, where visitors can shop for traditional fabrics, including beautifully dyed wax prints, as well as handcrafted jewelry, wooden masks, bronze statues, and woven baskets. Markets like Dantokpa Market in

Cotonou are cultural hubs, offering a wide variety of local goods and souvenirs. It's a great place to experience everyday life, practice your bargaining skills, and take home a piece of Benin's rich artisan heritage.

25. Can I make personal purchases?

Yes, budget around \$8-\$25 per day for personal expenses like snacks, drinks, and souvenirs. Larger purchases can be made with credit cards in major stores.

Prepare to be Amazed!

Beneath the vibrant energy of modern Benin lies a land steeped in royal legacy, spiritual tradition, and rich cultural heritage. From the ancient Kingdom of Dahomey to the birthplace of Vodun (Voodoo), Benin is a fascinating blend of the historical, the indigenous, the mystical, and the modern. Benin is bold, beautiful, and unforgettable. Have your cameras ready!

The African Connections Team is eagerly awaiting your arrival in Benin and stands ready to assist you as you prepare for an inspiring and immersive West African adventure!